

Word family: **shelf / shelves / shelve / shelved / shelving**

Base word: shelf

Plural: shelves

Part of speech: mainly **noun**

Related forms:

* **shelf** (n.) — 架；層架；棚；陸架；冰架

* **shelves** (plural) — 架子；層架

* **shelve** (v.) — 把……放上架；擱置；暫緩

* **shelved** (adj./participle) — 被擱置的；被放上架的

* **shelving** (n.) — 層架；架子系統

* **shelf life** (n.) — 保存期限；貨架壽命

* **shelf-stable** (adj.) — 可常溫保存的

* **off-the-shelf** (adj.) — 現成的；非度身訂造的

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **on a shelf**

* **bookshelf**

* **top / bottom shelf**

* **put something on the shelf**

* **take something off the shelf**

* **shelf life**

* **shelf-stable**

* **off-the-shelf**

* **on the shelf**

* **continental shelf**

* **ice shelf**

* **shelve a plan**

* **shelve an idea**

* **shelving unit**

Meaning in this passage

> She kept it on a **shelf** in her room, and from time to time she would take it out again.

Here, **shelf** means:

**a flat horizontal surface fixed to a wall or inside furniture, used for storing or displaying things
— 架；層架；架板**

The mother kept the photo album on a shelf in her room rather than putting it away somewhere

inaccessible.

****中文翻譯：****

她把它放在房間的****架子上****，偶爾還會再拿出來翻看。

So here:

**shelf = 用來擺放、儲存或展示物件的水平架板**

1. **shelf (架；層架) — 架子；層架**

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> She kept the album on a ****shelf**** in her room.

她把相簿放在房間的****架子上****。

Practice 2

> The books are on the top ****shelf****.

那些書放在最上面的****層架****。

Practice 3

> I put the photo frame on a ****shelf****.

我把相架放在一個****架子上****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelf = 一塊水平的板，用來擺放、儲存或展示物品****

2. **shelves — 多層架；架子**

Practice 1

> The shop has several ****shelves**** of books.

這間店有幾****層書架****放滿書。

Practice 2

> The **shelves** were full of old photographs.

那些**架子**放滿了舊照片。

MCQ-ready definition:

shelves = shelf 的複數，即多個用來放置物件的水平架板

Grammar note:

The plural is:

> shelf → **shelves**

not:

> **shelfs** ❌

3. **bookshelf** — 書架

Practice 1

> The album was next to some books on the **bookshelf**.

相簿放在**書架**上的幾本書旁邊。

Practice 2

> She has a large **bookshelf** in her bedroom.

她睡房裏有一個大**書架**。

MCQ-ready definition:

bookshelf = 主要用來放書的架子或層架

4. **top / middle / bottom shelf** — 上層 / 中層 / 下層架

Practice 1

> The box is on the **top shelf**.

盒子放在**最上層架**。

Practice 2

> Put the heavy books on the **bottom shelf**.

把重書放在**最下層架**。

MCQ-ready definition:

top/bottom shelf = 多層架中最上 / 最下的一層

5. **take something off the shelf — 從架上取下**

Practice 1

> She **took the album off the shelf**.

她把相簿**從架上拿下來**。

Practice 2

> I **took a book off the shelf**.

我**從書架上拿下一本書**。

MCQ-ready definition:

take X off the shelf = 把 X 從架子上拿下來

6. **put something on the shelf — 把某物放上架**

Practice 1

> He **put the box on the shelf**.

他把盒子**放到架上**。

Practice 2

> Put the album back **on the shelf** when you're finished.

看完後把相簿**放回架上**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****put X on the shelf = 把 X 放到層架上****

7. ****shelf (天然突出的平坦部分) — 突出的平面；岩架****

A physical/geographical extension.

Practice 1

> The climber rested on a narrow rock ****shelf****.

攀山者在一塊狹窄的****岩架****上休息。

Practice 2

> A small ****shelf**** of rock projected from the cliff.

懸崖突出了一小塊平坦的****岩層平台****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelf = 天然形成、像架子一樣突出的狹窄平坦表面****

8. ****continental shelf — 大陸架****

A major geographical sense.

Practice 1

> The sea is relatively shallow over the ****continental shelf****.

****大陸架****上方的海水相對較淺。

Practice 2

> Oil deposits can be found beneath the ****continental shelf****.

****大陸架****下方可能有石油蘊藏。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****continental shelf = 大陸邊緣向海底延伸、相對平緩而較淺的區域****

9. **ice shelf — 冰架**

Practice 1

> Scientists are monitoring the Antarctic **ice shelf**.

科學家正在監測南極**冰架**。

Practice 2

> Part of the **ice shelf** broke away.

一部分**冰架**斷裂脫離。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****ice shelf = 與陸地冰相連、向海面延伸並浮在海上的一大片厚冰層****

10. **shelf life — 保存期限；貨架壽命**

A very important compound.

Practice 1

> Fresh milk has a short **shelf life**.

鮮奶的**保存期限**較短。

Practice 2

> Packaging can extend a product's **shelf life**.

包裝可以延長產品的**保存期**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelf life = 產品在變壞、失效或不適合使用前，可以安全或有效保存的時間****

11. **shelf life (figurative : 有效期 / 受歡迎期) — 有效期；生命週期**

The phrase can extend beyond food.

Practice 1

> Some technology products have a very short **shelf life**.

有些科技產品的市場**生命週期很短**。

Practice 2

> Online trends often have a short **shelf life**.

網絡潮流往往只有很短的**流行期 / 有效期**。

MCQ-ready definition:

shelf life = figuratively, 某事物保持有用、流行或相關性的時間

12. **shelf-stable** — 可常溫保存的

Practice 1

> These drinks are **shelf-stable**.

這些飲品可以**常溫保存**。

Practice 2

> **Shelf-stable food** does not need refrigeration before opening.

可常溫保存的食品在開封前不需要冷藏。

MCQ-ready definition:

shelf-stable = 在正常室溫下可以安全保存一段較長時間的

13. **off-the-shelf** — 現成的；標準化的

A major figurative/commercial compound.

Practice 1

> We bought an **off-the-shelf software package**.

我們購買了一套**現成的軟件套裝**。

Practice 2

> An **off-the-shelf solution** was cheaper than building one from scratch.

使用**現成方案**比從零開發便宜。

MCQ-ready definition:

off-the-shelf = 已經設計和製造好，可以直接購買使用，而不是專門度身訂造的

14. **off the shelf** — 從貨架直接買到；現成可用

Practice 1

> The equipment can be bought **off the shelf**.

這套設備可以直接**買現成的**。

Practice 2

> We chose a system available **off the shelf**.

我們選擇了一套**市面現成可買到的**系統。

MCQ-ready definition:

off the shelf = available as a ready-made standard product

15. **on the shelf** (商品：在貨架上出售) — 在售；擺上貨架

Practice 1

> The new product will be **on the shelves** next month.

新產品下月會**上架發售**。

Practice 2

> The book appeared **on store shelves** this week.

這本書本週正式**上架出售**。

MCQ-ready definition:

on the shelves = 已經在商店陳列並可供購買

16. **hit the shelves — 正式上架；推出市場**

A common retail/media expression.

Practice 1

> The new book **hits the shelves** next week.

新書下星期**正式上架**。

Practice 2

> The product **hit the shelves** in June.

產品六月**正式推出市場**。

MCQ-ready definition:

hit the shelves = become available for sale in shops

17. **fly off the shelves — 很快售罄；搶購一空**

A vivid figurative retail idiom.

Practice 1

> The new toys **flew off the shelves**.

新玩具很快便**搶購一空**。

Practice 2

> The book has been **flying off the shelves**.

這本書一直**非常暢銷**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fly off the shelves = sell extremely quickly

18. **shelve something (把.....放上架) — 把.....放到架上**

The literal verb.

Practice 1

> She **shelved the books** alphabetically.

她按字母順序把書**放上書架**。

Practice 2

> The librarian **shelved the returned books**.

圖書館員把歸還的書**放回書架**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelve something = 把某物放在架子上，尤其是把書放回書架****

19. **shelve a plan / idea / project — 擱置計劃 / 想法 / 項目**

A major figurative verb sense.

Practice 1

> The company **shelved the plan**.

公司**擱置了那個計劃**。

Practice 2

> They decided to **shelve the project** until next year.

他們決定把項目**暫時擱置**到明年。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelve X = 暫時或無限期停止考慮、推進或實行 X****

20. **be shelved — 被擱置**

Practice 1

> The proposal was **shelved** after the meeting.

提案在會議後被**擱置**。

Practice 2

> The film project was **shelved** for several years.

那個電影項目被**擱置了數年**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be shelved = 某個計劃、項目或提案被暫停，不再立即推進****

21. **shelving — 層架；架子系統**

Practice 1

> We installed new **shelving** in the study.

我們在書房安裝了新的**層架**。

Practice 2

> Adjustable **shelving** makes the cupboard more useful.

可調校的**層架系統**令櫃子更實用。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****shelving = 一組架板或用來組成架子的設備****

22. **on the shelf (figurative : 被擱置不用) — 被擱置；閒置**

Practice 1

> The idea stayed **on the shelf** for years.

這個想法多年來一直**被擱置**。

Practice 2

> Several completed projects were left **on the shelf**.

幾個已完成的項目被**擱在一旁沒有使用**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****on the shelf = figuratively, not currently being used, developed, or acted upon****

Important distinction 1: ****shelf vs rack****

****shelf****

flat horizontal surface.

****rack****

frame designed to hold things in a particular arrangement.

> bookshelf

書架

> clothes rack

衣架 / 掛衣架

A rack may contain shelves, but they are not identical.

Important distinction 2: ****shelf vs cupboard****

****shelf****

one horizontal surface.

****cupboard****

whole enclosed storage unit.

A cupboard may contain several shelves.

Important distinction 3: ****shelf vs cabinet****

****cabinet****

a complete piece of storage furniture, often with doors/drawers.

shelf

one open or internal horizontal storage surface.

Important distinction 4: **shelf vs ledge**

shelf

usually designed or naturally shaped for holding things.

ledge

a narrow horizontal projection from a wall, cliff, window, etc.

> bookshelf

書架

> window ledge

窗台邊緣

There is overlap in natural formations.

Important distinction 5: **shelf vs bookshelf**

shelf

one individual horizontal level.

bookshelf

either one shelf for books or, in everyday use, an entire piece of furniture containing shelves.

So:

> top shelf of the bookshelf

書架最上面的一層

Important distinction 6: ****shelf life does not mean how long something physically sits on a shelf****

It means:

****how long a product remains usable, safe, fresh, or commercially suitable****

A product may be stored somewhere other than a literal shelf and still have a shelf life.

Important distinction 7: ****shelf life vs expiry date****

****shelf life****

the length of time a product remains suitable.

****expiry date****

the specific date after which it should no longer be used/sold under the relevant rules.

> shelf life = 時段

> expiry date = 日期

Important distinction 8: ****off-the-shelf vs custom-made****

****off-the-shelf****

ready-made standard product.

****custom-made / bespoke****

created specifically for one customer or purpose.

> off-the-shelf software

現成軟件

> custom-built software

度身訂造軟件

Important distinction 9: ****shelve vs shelf****

****shelf****

noun:

> put it on the shelf

把它放上架

****shelve****

verb:

> shelve the books

把書放上架

The spelling changes:

> shelf → shelves

> shelve → shelved

Important distinction 10: ****shelve a plan does not mean physically put papers on a shelf****

This is figurative.

> shelve the plan

= ****暫停 / 擱置計劃****

The metaphor is:

> put something away on a shelf instead of continuing to use it.

Important distinction 11: ****shelve vs cancel****

****shelve****

often means postpone or stop for now; it may return later.

****cancel****

formally stop something that was planned.

> shelve a project

暫時擱置項目

> cancel a project

取消項目

****Shelve**** often leaves more possibility of revival.

Important distinction 12: ****shelve vs postpone****

****postpone****

move to a later time, often with the intention to continue.

****shelve****

put aside, often without a definite new date.

> postpone the meeting until Friday

把會議延至星期五

> shelve the proposal

把提案擱置

Important distinction 13: ****on the shelf literal vs figurative****

Literal

> The album is on the shelf.

相簿在架上。

Figurative

> The project is on the shelf.

項目被擱置。

Your passage uses the literal sense.

Important distinction 14: ****hit the shelves vs hit a shelf****

****hit the shelves****

idiom:

= 上架出售

****hit a shelf****

literal:

= 撞到架子

Completely different.

Important distinction 15: ****fly off the shelves****

Nothing is literally flying.

It means:

****sell extremely quickly****

The metaphor is of products disappearing rapidly from shop shelves.

Important distinction 16: ****continental shelf vs ordinary shelf****

****ordinary shelf****

furniture/storage.

****continental shelf****

geographical formation under the sea.

They share the image of a broad, relatively flat projecting surface, but belong to completely

different domains.

Important distinction 17: **ice shelf vs iceberg**

ice shelf

large floating extension of land-based ice, still attached to land/glacier.

iceberg

a detached floating mass of ice.

An iceberg can break off from an ice shelf.

Family-extension note

Shelf has several strong modern branches:

1. **storage/display surface**

- * shelf
- * bookshelf
- * top shelf
- * shelving

2. **natural horizontal formation**

- * rock shelf
- * continental shelf
- * ice shelf

3. **product lifespan**

- * shelf life
- * shelf-stable

4. **retail availability**

- * on the shelves
- * hit the shelves
- * fly off the shelves

5. **ready-made commercial product**

* off-the-shelf

6. **verb: physically store**

* shelve books

7. **verb: postpone**

* shelve a plan

* shelve a project

The central metaphor is:

something being placed on a flat surface and kept there

That physical idea extends naturally into:

> **put a plan on the shelf → stop actively working on it**

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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shelf	架子；層架	storage surface
shelves	多個架子 / 層架	plural
bookshelf	書架	book storage
top shelf	最上層架	position
take X off the shelf	從架上拿下 X	physical removal
put X on the shelf	把 X 放上架	physical storage
rock shelf	岩架	natural ledge
continental shelf	大陸架	underwater landform
ice shelf	冰架	floating attached ice
shelf life	保存期限	usable period
shelf life (figurative)	有效期 / 流行期	relevance period
shelf-stable	可常溫保存的	storage stability
off-the-shelf	現成的	ready-made
on the shelves	上架出售	retail availability
hit the shelves	正式上架	launch for sale
fly off the shelves	搶購一空	sell quickly
shelve books	把書放上架	literal verb
shelve a plan	擱置計劃	postpone/stop
be shelved	被擱置	inactive

shelving	層架系統	storage structure	
on the shelf (figurative)	被擱置	unused/inactive	

For your original sentence

> She kept it on a **shelf** in her room, and from time to time she would take it out again.

Here:

shelf = 房間裏用來放置物品的實體架子 / 層架

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 她把它放在房間的**架子上**，偶爾還會再拿出來翻看。

And there is a nice contextual detail here: the album was **on a shelf**, not packed away in a box. That suggests it remained accessible and was something she genuinely returned to from time to time.